Art on the Wall: Why Cities Need Artists

Day 1 · Reading (1 of 2)

What to do: Read it aloud, one paragraph each. Stop at every blue word: can anybody explain it?

Vocabulary topic: Art, artists and the city
20 new words (in blue) · EEW 1, Unit 12 · read about art in the city and talk about opinions and possibilities



easy parts harder parts (most new words are here)

Walk through a big city and look up. You see windows, balconies, signs and, sometimes, a huge painting on a wall. Street art is one of the most colorful parts of modern life. A hundred years ago, nobody thought about **artists** on city walls. Today some streets are museums in the open air.

Why do cities need art? Experts say that art changes the **attitude** of people to their street. A gray wall can make people feel **alone**, but a colorful wall makes them stop and smile. In some cities, the number of crimes went down after painters decorated the walls. You can **compare** two streets, one with art and one without, and you can see the difference in the **quality** of life with your own eyes.

Many people live in an **apartment** in a big building, and they hardly know their **neighbor**. One neighbor hears the music, another hears the television, and nobody says hello. A small piece of art in the entrance can change this. People stop, look and start to talk.

Artists use many kinds of **material**: paint, stone, wood, metal and even old plastic. A **professional** artist looks at a boring thing, like an old bicycle or a broken chair, and sees a new **shape**. Her **method** is simple: she looks for a new idea in an old object. A good picture does not need much **space**: a small card can tell a whole story. Some artists use **thin** lines, others use thick ones, and both can be beautiful.

Are you an artist? Everyone is, a little. A child draws a house with a sun and a tree: that is art. A cook makes a beautiful **meal**: that is art, too. You do not need a school to enjoy making something with your hands.

Art on the Wall: Why Cities Need Artists

Day 1 · Reading (2 of 2)

What to do: After reading: which paragraphs were easy, which were hard? Which blue words did you know already?

Not everybody agrees about what art is. To **judge** a picture is not easy: some people see a masterpiece, others see a mess. In 2019 an artist sold a banana taped to a wall for a very high price, and people argued about it for months. A single work can bring a big **profit** to a gallery, and the same work can be worth nothing to your neighbor. Is a thing art if nobody likes it? That is a question for philosophers.

A **magazine** is a good place to start. Open an art magazine and look at ten pictures. Which one do you like most? Write one sentence about it. Then read an **article** about the picture. Did your opinion change?

Every picture has a **symbol**: a dove for peace, a heart for love, a red rose for passion. In many cultures, a blue eye on the wall protects the house. When you walk up the **stairs** of an old building, look at the details. Sometimes the artist leaves a small symbol on the wall, and only a careful visitor finds it.

Try this: take a pencil and a piece of paper and draw your own street from memory. Do not look at a photo. Which details did you remember? Which did you forget? Artists use this exercise to train their eyes.

Some cities use art to solve practical problems. In one city, painters changed a dark tunnel into a bright gallery, and people felt safer there. In another, children painted the stairs of a hospital with animals and numbers, and the visits became less scary. Art can be a language that every person understands, even without words.

In your book, Unit 12, an artist works alone in his apartment for many years. In the end, the other artists do not understand his painting. It is a story about art, time and loneliness. Read it and decide what you think. Might he be right? Might they be right?

The 20 words

Day 1 · Vocabulary table · Topic: Art, artists and the city

What to do: Book: 4000 EEW 1, Unit 12, pages 74–77. Copy the words you do not know into the copybook.

Word	Meaning	По-русски	Example
alone adj./adv.	without other people	один, в одиночестве	She lives alone.
apartment n.	a home in a big building	квартира	We live in an apartment on the fifth floor.
article n.	a piece of writing in a newspaper or magazine	статья	I read an interesting article about space.
artist n.	a person who paints, draws or makes art	художник	The artist is painting a portrait.
attitude n.	the way you think and feel about something	отношение	She has a positive attitude to life.
compare v.	look at how two things are the same or different	сравнивать	Compare the two pictures.
judge n./v.	form an opinion about something; a person in a court	судья; судить	The judges chose the best picture.
magazine n.	a thin book with articles and pictures, published often	журнал	He reads a car magazine every month.
material n.	what something is made of	материал	Wood is a natural material.
meal n.	the food you eat at one time	еда, приём пищи	Breakfast is my favorite meal.
method n.	a way of doing something	метод, способ	This is a new method of learning words.
neighbor n.	a person who lives next to you	сосед	Our neighbor has a big dog.
professional adj.	doing something as a job, with great skill	профессиональный	He is a professional footballer.
profit n.	money you get after paying all costs	прибыль	The shop made a big profit this year.
quality n.	how good or bad something is	качество	These shoes are of good quality.
shape n.	the form of something, like a circle	форма	A ball has a round shape.
space n.	an empty place; the area outside Earth	пространство, место; космос	There is no space for my bike.
stair n.	one step in a group of steps	ступенька; лестница	Go up the stairs to the third floor.
symbol n.	a sign that means something else	символ	The heart is a symbol of love.
thin adj.	not thick or fat	тонкий, худой	The cat is very thin.

More on the topic

Day 1 · Topic: Art, artists and the city · more words

What to do: Choose 5 collocations to learn. Use the reserve words when a student already knows the main ones.

Collocations: words that go together

a professional artist	профессиональный художник
an art magazine	журнал об искусстве
write an article	написать статью
a good quality · poor quality	хорошее качество · плохое
a method of work	метод работы
a symbol of peace	символ мира
judge a book by its cover	судить по обложке
a thin line	тонкая линия
live alone	жить одному
a new attitude	новое отношение
compare A with B	сравнивать A с B
make a profit	получать прибыль

Phrasal verbs

look at	смотреть на	Look at this picture.
find out	выяснить	Find out who painted it.
point out	указать	The guide pointed out a small symbol.
turn out	оказаться	The painting turned out to be famous.
come up with	придумать	She came up with a new idea.
work on	работать над	He worked on the painting for years.

Reserve words: for students who know the 20 already, or if you prefer another word

paint	краска; рисовать	**wall**	стена
brush	кисть	**color**	цвет
canvas	холст	**sculpture**	скульптура
gallery	галерея	**exhibition**	выставка
museum	музей	**masterpiece**	шедевр

What to read next · 4000 Essential English Words

This week: **Book 1, Unit 12, “The Crazy Artist”**, pages 74–79. Next: the **Level test**, Units 1–12. About a painting and a rich life: **Unit 10, “The First Peacock”**, pages 62–67.